



Death of Parthian

R. Meyer
(Oxford)

bit.ly/PthICIL8

Parthian: eras

Differences

Question

Armenian

Concluding
proposal

The first ‘death’ of Parthian

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Outline

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- 1 The two eras of Parthian
- 2 Key differences between inscriptional and Manichaean Parthian
- 3 The main question: what happened in-between?
- 4 Parthian influence on Armenian
- 5 Concluding proposal: superstrate shift & language death



Parthian: the basics

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- ▶ Parthian is the northern member of the West Middle Iranian languages
 - also southern Middle Persian and, potentially, an unattested third language, cf. e.g. KORN AND OLSEN (2012)
- ▶ one of the key languages of communication and administration of the Arsacid Parthian Empire
 - also used in other Parthian-dominated polities (esp. Kingdoms of Armenia, Iberia) and along the Silk Road as a *lingua franca*
- ▶ attested in two different eras and regions
 - ▶ how come?



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Parthian: a map of findings

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- ▶ **Silk Road** (very simplified and selective)
- ▶ early attestation (C1 BCE – C3 CE)
- ▶ **late findings** (> C6 CE)



Key differences between inscriptional and Manichaean Parthian I

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- ▶ mentioned already / implicit: geography, time of *attestation*, content
- ▶ linguistic differences (selection):
 - ▶ lexicon: Manichaean texts show greater Indo-Aryan influences, esp. Gāndhārī-Prākrit loans (SIMS-WILLIAMS 1983)
 - ▶ morphology: (even greater) loss of (pro-)nominal morphology (SKJÆRVØ 1983:49, 176 with the caveat of SIMS-WILLIAMS 1981: 166–70)
 - ▶ syntax: loss of ergative alignment in favour of nominative in later texts



Key differences between inscriptional and Manichaean Parthian II

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Examples:

Morphology (reconstructed on inscr. evidence from MP & Pth.)

Early	SG	PL	Later	SG	PL
DIR	-Ø	-Ø		-Ø	-Ø / -ān, -īn, -ūn
OBL	-ē	-ān		-Ø	-ān, -īn, -ūn

Syntax

- (1) *u-m tō saxwan išnūd Ø*
and-1.SG 2.SG.POSS speech hear.PST Ø
'... and I have heard your speech ...' (MKG(1398–1400))
- (2) *ud wāxt-ēnd: kū ...*
and say.PST-3.PL COMP
'And they said (that) ...' (MKG(145))



The main question: what happened in-between?

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- 1 Why is Parthian not attested in monumental inscriptions post-296 CE?
- 2 How can we account for the early 'death' of Parthian in the West compared to its 'survival' in the East?
- 3 Why are there no (significant) sources of Parthian writing vel sim. in the other Parthian-ruled polities?



Ad 1: The fall of the Parthian Empire

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- ▶ fall of the Parthian Empire in 224 CE
- ▶ rise of the Sasanians (speakers of Middle Persian)
 - ▶ likely mutually intelligible with Parthian; cf. SUNDERMANN (1989a: 106, 110); DURKIN-MEISTERERNST (2014:1); POSCH (1998:358)
- ▶ Parthian likely used for a while as a legacy chancery language
- ▶ while Parthian-speakers still a relevant part of population, relegation to second rank in terms of political influence

DURKIN-MEISTERERNST (2014:5)

Da die Sasaniden Mp [Middle Persian] sprachen und von keinem Sasanidenkönig nur eine pa [Parthian] Inschrift ohne mp Version (aber auch von Narseh keine ausschließlich mp. Inschrift) überliefert ist, und da noch vor der letzten pa Inschrift der Oberpriester Kerdīr seine Inschriften nur auf mp anfertigen ließ, scheint das Pa in diesen Inschriften sekundär zu sein oder es zumindest im Laufe der Bezeugung zu werden.



Ad 2: Attestation vs usage

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- ▶ attestation in pre-Sasanian times is poor at best – likely owed to the oral character of Parthian literature and the use of Aramaic in monumental inscriptions (cf. SUNDERMANN 1989*b*:114)
- ▶ the core of later-attested Manichaean literature **must** stem from this time period (given that Mani lived c. 216–274 CE)
- ▶ spread to the East as part of Manichaean missions via the Silk Road
 - ▶ more successful there owing to less pressure from Christianity, Zoroastrianism, and later Islam (cf. LIEU 1992:145–8)
- ▶ attestation ≠ usage: Parthian likely lived on actively beyond its Western attestation, but only leaves traces in later documents
- ▶ then clearly was maintained as a heritage, later liturgical language
- ▶ worth remembering that then (and now) multilingualism was the rule



Ad 3: Parthian in Armenia?

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Remaining question

Why is there no substantial evidence of Parthian in the Arsacid kingdom of Armenia, esp. during Arsacid dynastic rule (198–428 CE)



Armenian: a very condensed brief I

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Parthian: eras

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Armenian

Concluding
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- ▶ Armenian is an Indo-European language, maybe most closely related to Greek, Phrygian, Albanian (Pontic Group; for isoglosses, cf. HOLST 2009; more critically CLACKSON 1994)
- ▶ first attested c. 480 CE (Sinai inscriptions), first MS in c. C9 CE
- ▶ considered an Iranian language until HÜBSCHMANN (1875)
- ▶ strong influence from (mainly but not exclusively) Parthian in many categories:
phonology, lexicon, derivational morphology, syntax
- ▶ statistics suggest that only 22% of Classical Armenian vocabulary (as per HÜBSCHMANN's 1897 analysis) are *echtarmenisch*, more than 30% Parthian (BELARDI 2003:98–102)



Armenian: a very condensed brief II

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Parthian: eras

Differences

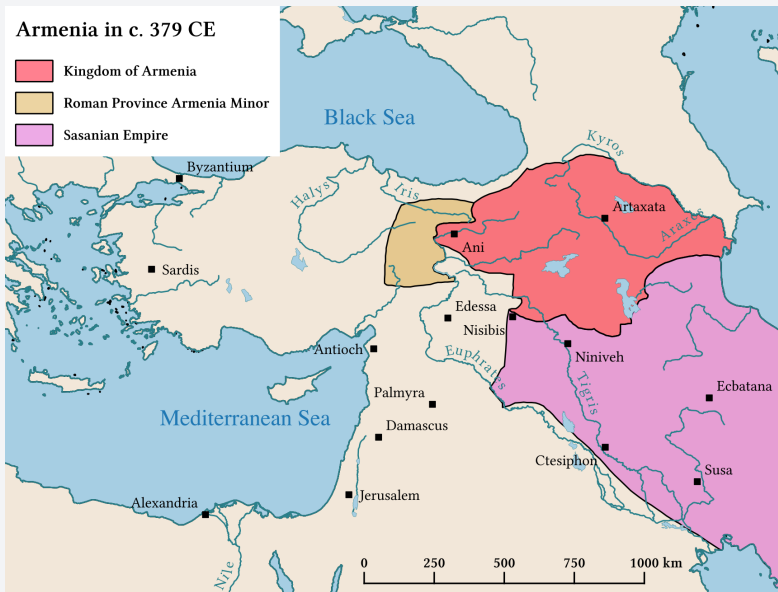
Question

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Armenia in c. 379 CE

- Kingdom of Armenia
- Roman Province Armenia Minor
- Sasanian Empire





Armenian history: an even more condensed brief

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Parthian: eras

Differences

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- ▶ C6 BCE – C5 CE: ruled by Iranians (varying dynasties, with interruptions)
 - ! more than 1,000 years (GARSOÏAN 1997*a,b,c*; RUSSELL 1997)
- ▶ 66 – 428 CE: Arsacid rule (junior branch of Parthian ruling dynasty), hereditary from 198 CE
- ▶ fall of the Parthian Empire (224 CE), ensuing political quarrels with the Sasanian successor state
- ▶ Christinisation of Armenia in c. 301–14 – as opposed to Sasanian Zoroastrianism
- ▶ frequent Armenian–Iranian intermarriage, tutelage system



Iranian influence: lexicon

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- ▶ Pth. loans are pervasive throughout lexicon (specialised and basic), incl. closed classes

Pth. loan words in Arm.

	Arm.	Pth.
‘army’	<i>zawr</i>	<i>z’wr /zāwar/</i>
‘root’	<i>bun</i>	<i>bwn /bun/</i>
‘white’	<i>spitak</i>	‘ <i>spyd /ispēd/</i>
‘1,000’	<i>hazar</i>	<i>hz’r /hazār/</i>
‘because of’	<i>vasn</i>	<i>wsn’d /wasnāδ/</i>

- ▶ Middle Persian and Old Iranian loans restricted to specialised vocabulary (esp. administration, military)
- ▶ Pth. phonemes are imported with lexical items (spreading into native words)
- ▶ references: BOLOGNESI (1960); MEYER (2017); SCHMITT (1983)



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- ▶ calques of various types occur, esp. in complex predicates and nominal compounds

Pth. calques in Arm.

	Arm.	Pth.	lit.
‘friend’	<i>barekam</i>	<i>šyrg’mg</i> /šīrgāmag/	‘well-wisher’
‘prisoner’	<i>jerbakal</i>	<i>dstgrb</i> /dastgraß/	‘taken by the hand’
‘to remove’	<i>heji ainel</i>	<i>dwr kr-</i> /dūr kar-/	‘to make far’

- ▶ complex predicates frequently only attested in Modern Persian evidence owing to limited Middle Iranian data
- ▶ further reference: BOLOGNESI (1961, 2006)



Iranian influence: syntax

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Parthian: *eras*

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- ▶ usage of the intensifier Arm. *ink'n* 'self' also as anaphora and (to a lesser extent) as switch-function marker – exact parallel in Pth. *wxd* /*wxad*/ and MP *xwd* /*xwad*/ (MEYER 2013)
- ▶ canonical reflexive Arm. *anjn iwr* modelled on Pth. *xwyš gryw* / *xwēš grīw*/ 'own body/self'
- ▶ use of complementiser Arm. *(e)t'ē* also as quotative and indirect statement/question marker, just like WMIr. *kw* /*kū*/ (rare elsewhere; MEYER 2017)
- ▶ split-tripartite morphosyntactic alignment in the Armenian perfect resulting from earlier (pre-literary) pattern replication of the Parthian split-ergative past tense (MEYER 2016, 2017)



Proposal: superstrate shift & language death I

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- ▶ contact between Armenian and Iranian (in general) and Parthian (in particular) both prolonged and intense as indicated by syntactic influence
- ▶ syntactic influence is common in language shift situations (related to multilingual acquisition; cf. THOMASON 2003:692; HEINE AND KUTEVA 2008:77) and the socio-historic setting fits the bill

thus Proposal: Parthian minority superstrate shifts to Armenian (as main, if no exclusive means of communication)

and Result: 'death' of Parthian in the region

- ▶ arguably not the first shift in Parthian history (HENNING 1958; LECOQ 1986)
- ▶ cp. situation in post-conquest Britain (BERNDT 1965; SCHENDL 2000; SHORT 1980)



Proposal: superstrate shift & language death II

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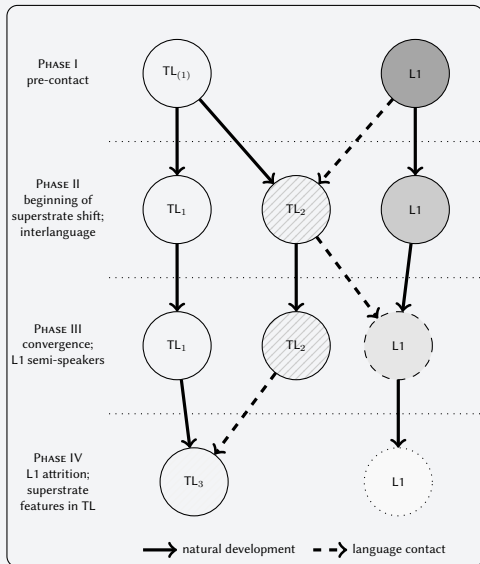
Parthian: eras

Differences

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Proposal: superstrate shift & language death III

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- ▶ the lack of data makes it impossible to verify this scenario, but it explains both the strongly iranianised character of Armenian and the lack of attestation of Parthian
- ▶ this could be extended to the Sasanian Empire (bilingualism with diglossia amongst the Parthian populace)



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Շատ շնորհակալություն!
Thank you for your attention!



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